

Boundary Language Worksheet

Practice Saying No with Confidence (and Without Guilt)

Use for self-led or facilitated learning

Instructions:

Read each of the 3 workplace scenarios below. For each one:

1. Use the 4 Self-Check Questions (see end of sheet).
2. Notice emotional triggers like guilt, pressure, or fear of disappointing.
3. Decide: **Yes**, **No**, or **Yes with limits**.
4. Choose a phrase from the examples or write your own.
5. Say your response out loud. Notice how it feels. Adjust tone or wording if needed.

Scenario 1: The Last-Minute Request

You've just sat down to start a time-sensitive report. A colleague pops by and says:
"Can you review this presentation? I just need fresh eyes before I send it out—shouldn't take long."

Your choice:

- Say no
- Say yes with conditions (e.g., later today)
- Offer another solution

Try it out:

"I'm working on something urgent right now. Can I look at it later this afternoon?"

"I want to help, but I'm tight on time. Would someone else on the team be available?"

Your own phrase: _____

Scenario 2: The Overflow Ask

You're already covering for a teammate who's away when your manager asks:

"Would you be able to take on the logistics for Friday's team lunch as well?"

Your choice:

- Decline clearly
- Say yes, but clarify scope
- Offer an alternative

Try it out:

“With [person] away, I’m at full capacity. I wouldn’t be able to do it well this week.”

“I can help with the lunch only if I can drop [another task] from my plate.”

Your own phrase: _____

Scenario 3: The Friendly Favour

A coworker you get along with texts after hours:

“Hey! I know it’s last minute, but can you help me prep for tomorrow’s presentation? I’m kind of freaking out.”

Your choice:

- Say no and protect your evening
- Say yes with a time boundary
- Redirect support

Try it out:

“I can’t tonight—I’m offline—but I can spare 15 minutes early tomorrow if that helps.”

“I want to help, but I need to stick to my boundaries after hours. Can you send me what you’ve got and I’ll review first thing?”

Your own phrase: _____

After Each Scenario, Reflect:

- What helped you decide whether to say yes or no?
- What tone did you use?
- Did the wording feel natural to you?
- How might you adjust your phrasing to fit your culture or communication style?

Check Yourself First: 4 Questions Before You Say Yes

1. What are my current priorities?
2. Do I realistically have time and energy for this?
3. What will I need to say no to if I say yes to this?
4. Does this align with my role or goals?